

Exile, Not Empire: The Posture of God's People

Elect exiles, a letter to Babylon, and a refusal in front of a furnace. What changes when the church stops reading like a landlord.

THE ADDRESS

Elect Exiles

Peter opens his first letter with an address that should unsettle every American reader: to the elect exiles of the dispersion in Pontus, Galatia, Cappadocia, Asia, and Bithynia. Elect and exiles. Chosen by God, displaced in the world, both at once and permanently.

John Elliott's work on this letter showed that the language is not decorative. *Paroikoi*, resident aliens, was a legal and social category in the Roman world: people who lived in a place without the standing of citizens, useful to the city and never quite of it. Peter takes that humiliating status and makes it a vocation. You are aliens, he says, and then adds the unthinkable, of God's own choosing.

Read the rest of the letter under that address and its strategy becomes clear. Honor the emperor, but fear only God. Live such good lives among the pagans that slander dies of embarrassment. Expect suffering and refuse to be surprised by it. Nothing in the letter reads like the correspondence of people who expect to run the empire. Everything in it reads like instructions for guests who answer to a different throne. That was the church's founding posture. We have mostly lost it.

THE LETTER

Seek the City, Do Not Become It

Six centuries earlier, Jeremiah wrote to the first wave of deportees in Babylon, and his letter cuts in both directions at once.

Against despair he says: build houses, plant gardens, marry, raise children, seek the shalom of the city where I have sent you, and pray to the Lord on its behalf, for in its welfare you will find your own. Babylon's good is your assignment. No withdrawal, no enclave, no sullen waiting by the gate for

evacuation.

Against assimilation he says: do not listen to the prophets among you who tell you what you want to hear. Hananiah was promising a short exile and a quick restoration of national glory. Jeremiah called that a lie and told the people to settle in for seventy years. Love the city. Do not become the city. Bless Babylon without bowing to Babylon's gods or believing Babylon's promises about itself.

That double command is the whole posture, and American Christians keep splitting it down the middle. Some of us seek the city's welfare and quietly adopt its worship. Others keep the faith pure and refuse the city our prayers. Jeremiah would recognize both failures. He would also recognize both flags.

THE COURT

Serve the King, Refuse the Statue

Daniel shows the posture lived out at the highest altitude of pagan power. He is taken as a teenager, renamed for a Babylonian god, trained in the literature of the empire that burned his city. He excels. He serves Nebuchadnezzar, then Belshazzar, then Darius, administering the very kingdom that destroyed Jerusalem, and Scripture records no rebuke for it.

But there is a line, and Daniel's circle knows where it is before the music plays. His three friends will run Babylon's provinces, and they will not bow to Babylon's statue. Their answer to the king may be the most politically clarifying sentence in the Old Testament: our God is able to deliver us, but if not, we will not serve your gods. If not. No guarantee of winning. No requirement of winning. Faithfulness was never indexed to outcome.

Notice what Daniel never does. He never organizes the exiles to seize Babylon. He never withdraws to keep his hands clean. He serves at the king's table and prays toward Jerusalem with the windows open, knowing exactly what the open windows will cost. Service without worship. Presence without capture. It can be done. It is simply expensive.

THE INHERITANCE

Owners in Our Own Minds

Why does this posture feel so foreign to us? Because American Christians inherited Christendom's reflexes without its throne. For fifteen centuries the church in the West sat near power, and the habits of ownership set deep. Hauerwas and Willimon named the moment of collapse and the strange gift inside it: the world ended, they said, sometime in the 1960s, and the church was free again to be the church. Most of us did not want the freedom. We wanted the building back.

The right grieves Christendom openly. Take back the country, restore the heritage, recover the deed. The left runs the same ownership program under different management, certain that the nation's institutions

exist to enact the kingdom's agenda, properly updated. Listen closely and both speak as landlords. Neither sounds like Peter's resident aliens, and I have spoken both dialects fluently from a pulpit in Michigan.

Newbigin saw the deeper problem when he returned from India to a post-Christian England: a church that has owned the culture cannot see the culture, and cannot really see itself. Exile restores sight. It is the one gift of lost establishment, and we keep refusing to open it.

THE TURN

What the Guest Can Finally See

What actually changes when you read Scripture as a guest rather than an owner?

Romans 13 changes. It becomes what it was, counsel to a powerless minority on surviving an empire honorably, not a chaplain's blessing on whoever currently governs. The prophets change. Their indictments land on me and my church before they land on Washington, because the courtroom of the prophets was always God's own people first. Even the Great Commission changes. Guests make disciples by witness, by suffering, by washing feet. Owners make them by statute, and the record of that method is written across centuries of baptized unbelief.

And prayer changes. The exile prays for the city differently than the owner does. The owner prays to win. The guest prays for a shalom he may never personally collect, for a welfare that includes his opponents, because Jeremiah told him his own peace is bound up in theirs.

We are not owners here. We never were. The deed we keep fighting over belongs to a kingdom that does not hold elections, and the sooner we grieve the throne we never had, the sooner we will be of use to the city we actually live in.

KEY TEXTS

1 Peter 2:11-12

Jeremiah 29:4-7

Daniel 3:16-18

SOURCES

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Resident Aliens: Life in the Christian Colony — Stanley Hauerwas and William H. Willimon

Cadences of Home: Preaching Among Exiles — Walter Brueggemann

Foolishness to the Greeks: The Gospel and Western Culture — Lesslie Newbigin